

Basic equipment

Here is a selection of the basic equipment you might find helpful.

Torch



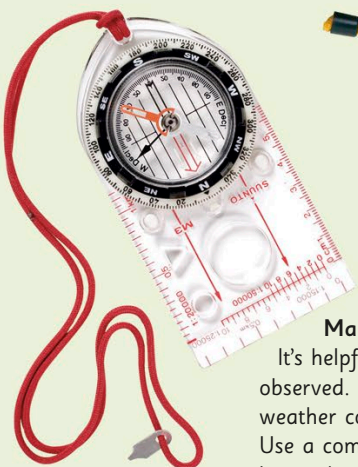
Torchlight tip

If you need to look at a star map while outside, cover the end of your torch in red cellophane. Red light doesn't interfere so much with night vision as white light.

Make notes

It's helpful to note what you have observed. Note the time, year, date, weather conditions, and location. Use a compass if you can, so you know the direction you are looking in.

Compass



Binoculars

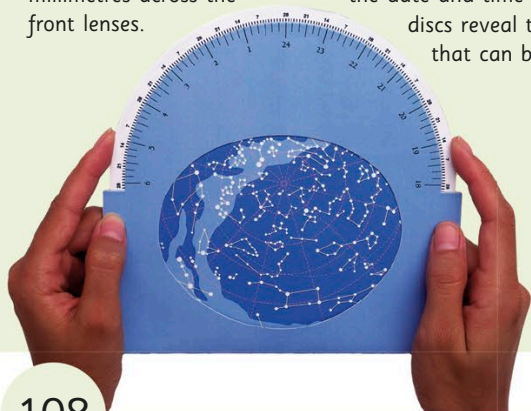


It's an 8 x 30!

Binoculars are sold in different sizes and powers. The numbers tell you what they are. The first tells you by how many times the binoculars will magnify an object. The second is the measurement in millimetres across the front lenses.

Star maps

It may be worth buying a planisphere. This is a circular map of the stars, made from two plastic discs. Line up the date and time and the discs reveal the stars that can be seen.



Become a stargazer

So you've decided to take a look at the night sky. What will you need to get you going? What should you look for? Here are a few tips to help get you started.

An ancient skill

Astronomy is the study of the Universe. The word "astronomy" comes from two Greek words – *astron*, meaning "star", and *nemein*, meaning "to name".



Larger lenses gather more light, but the larger the lens, the heavier the binoculars.

Holding binoculars steady while looking at the night sky can make your arms ache. Try to find something on which you can rest your arms.